

SECTION 4

Developing Your Employees

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Do You Know What Motivates Your Team?

by Rik Nemanick

You may have seen it play out before: A star performer is promoted to lead a team of peers but struggles to get the most out of them. In fact, you may be (or have been) that leader. This experience is surprisingly common in organizations of all sizes and across professions. The new leader thinks, “I’ll lead by example. I’ll show them how hard I work and that will inspire them to work just as hard.” That logic, however, is flawed.

Psychologist Daniel Goleman has referred to this style of leadership as “pacesetting.”¹ It happens when the leader sets a high bar for performance and works hard (and often long hours) to raise expectations for the rest of the team. The leader runs like a pacer in a race, but runs faster than everyone else, hoping to inspire them to catch up. While a few team members can temporarily keep up, the rest slow down or push back, and the team’s performance starts to deteriorate.

The gap between what the leader is trying to accomplish and what’s actually achieved is often due to a mismatch in sources of motivation. The leader likely has an innate competitive drive and a strong focus on career goals. The team members probably have different motives that stem from their own ambitions, values, and individual goals, which are often different from the leader’s.

As someone new to leadership, it can be easy to rely on pacesetting. You were likely promoted into your role due to your outstanding performance as an individual contributor, and now you want to hold other people to that same standard. But, as Goleman notes, pacesetting tends to erode trust and drive a wedge between managers and their teams.

When you aren’t on the same page as your subordinates, several bad habits can start to sneak in. You may hesitate to delegate tasks because no one can meet your expectations. In fact, you may be tempted to take over some of your team’s responsibilities since they don’t have the same sense of urgency as you. You may become visibly frustrated with people and have lots of corrective feedback. You may even begin to divide important tasks and projects between the one or two team members you can trust (and who are likely the runners trying to keep pace with you).

While I don’t suggest that young and ambitious leaders completely water down their high standards, if you want to get the most out of your team, it’s important to recognize that each person has their own motives. Slowing down to learn those motives can help you find more effective ways to encourage each person to do their best work.

What Motivates Your Team?

Unfortunately, learning what motivates other people is not as straightforward as directly asking someone, “What motivates you?” Most of us struggle to articulate our actual motives and may not be fully conscious of them. A better approach, and one I’ve coached many leaders to take, involves asking three powerful questions focused on the past, the present, and the future.

Look backward: What have you accomplished?

The first question I tell my clients to ask is, “What have you accomplished in the last four to six months that makes you most proud?” I tell them to follow that question with, “What about that work makes you proud?”

The first answer gives them insight into the kind of work their team members like to do, and the second tells them what about that work makes them feel motivated.

When you ask these questions of your own team, the key is to listen for hints of intrinsic motivation—or the incentive we feel to complete a task just because we find it engaging or enjoyable. For example, if your team member answers the first question and says they’re proud of writing a viral social media post simply because they really love that kind of work, they were likely intrinsically motivated by it. Now, your job is to find out why.

There are a few components that drive intrinsic motivation: competence, autonomy, and connectedness, according to self-determination theory (SDT).² Let’s take a closer look at each:

Competence: If your team member says they find social media writing rewarding because it comes naturally to them and they find it validating when other people share their content, they may be motivated by work that makes them feel competent. SDT postulates that the satisfaction we feel when we overcome a challenge and perform well makes us feel more competent, which then leads us to feel intrinsically motivated.

Autonomy: If your team member is proud because they wrote the post in their own way without the guidance of anyone else, they likely value and are driven by the feeling of autonomy. In fact, psychologists have found that competency and autonomy often play off each other.

Connectedness: If your team member is proud because they collaborated well with others to write the post and saw it resonate widely, they may be motivated by connectedness. This means the task itself wasn’t as motivating as being part of a group that accomplished it together, providing a sense of belonging.

You may hear about what accomplishing the task meant to your team member. Though this isn’t included in SDT, many of us are motivated by work that is meaningful and has a purpose.

As you listen to the answers, make note of what made your team member proud (competency, autonomy, connectedness, or purpose). Start to think about what responsibilities align best with those sources of motivation. For instance, if your team member described how they worked as part of a team (connectedness) to solve an important problem (purpose), you might think about other projects you could assign them to feed these internal drives.

Look at today: What is getting in your way today?

The second question can help surface demotivators, or things that are frustrating your team and sapping their motivation. A big part of your job as a leader is to remove the barriers blocking their potential. Beyond that, this question will give your people an opportunity to feel heard and appreciated.

Some leaders are afraid to ask about barriers for fear of surfacing things they can’t change (hard deadlines or limited resources). Others worry that the conversation will devolve into a complaining session. To move past these fears, remind yourself that not every roadblock can or needs to be overcome—listening and caring can be enough. Showing empathy and being open to looking for ways to compensate for or work around a roadblock can go a long way and even help unblock your team member for the time being.

When your team member shares their frustrations, ask, “What do you think we can do about that?” (Depending on the issue, you might substitute “we” with “you” or “I.”) If the issue is truly unsolvable, discuss how your team member can still be effective given the constraint. Even if the solution isn’t obvious, you’re still building a foundation of trust, connecting, and surfacing a frustrating problem. You’ll gain information that can help you prevent similar barriers in the future.

Look forward: What would you like to do more of?

The final question opens the door to what your team member would like more of going forward. There may be things they want but have never communicated to you—either because they couldn’t find the right time or felt they needed permission to ask.

One team member may want to learn a new skill, while another wants to tackle a challenging project. One person may want to participate in a mentoring program, while another wants to gain experience in a different department.

As a leader, you don't have to fulfill every request, but asking the question will help you figure out how to make their jobs more interesting and motivating. It will create some room for job crafting, which involves making small changes to better fit the role to the individual.

How and When Should You Ask These Questions?

Each of these questions has the potential to yield powerful insights, but you need to be conscious of when and how you hold the conversation to see them. Here are a few tips.

Time it right

While these questions might feel like a natural fit for your annual performance evaluations, I would advise asking them sooner. The end of the year is not the time to make amends for lost motivation.

Motivating your team and helping them grow is part of your daily job. That's why I recommend asking these questions during a regularly scheduled one-on-one meeting and make them the entire focus. This will give you the space you need to have a meaningful conversation and start making changes sooner rather than later.

Give your team member a heads-up

Don't ask your team member these questions on the spot. To get the most thoughtful answers, they'll likely need some time to reflect and prepare. Consider sending the questions via email in advance of your meeting.

You might say, "In preparation for our meeting this week, I wanted you to ponder three questions. Not only will these help you reflect on your work and your future goals, but your responses will also help me plan for your growth and development."

Don't make it a onetime thing

You should be having this conversation about every six to 12 months. It's a good way to check in with your people on something besides what they are working on right now. You can also use each subsequent meeting to get feedback on any changes that have come about since your last discussion. Be sure to listen actively, take notes, and repeat back any major points your team member makes to show that you're paying attention.

The ultimate goal is to make your team members feel heard and cared for while uncovering their deepest motives. If you approach these discussions with a curious mindset and make them a regular practice, you will find them paying dividends in the form of team cohesiveness, productivity, and morale.

QUICK RECAP

To figure out what motivates your team members, ask them three powerful questions focused on the past, the present, and the future.

- **What have you accomplished that you're proud of?** Listen for hints of intrinsic motivation and think about projects you could assign them to feed those internal drives.
 - **What is getting in the way today?** Surface demotivators or things that are frustrating your team. Then, try to remove the barriers blocking their potential.
 - **What would you like to do more of?** Use the answer to figure out how to make their jobs more interesting and motivating going forward.
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Adapted from content posted on hbr.org, October 16, 2023.

To learn more about motivating employees, listen to this podcast:



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How to Stop Micromanaging and Start Empowering

by Lia Garvin

As a new manager, you care. A lot. You care about your team, the work you're doing, the way you're perceived by company leaders—the list goes on.

Caring can be a good thing. But when it turns into having to control every single thing, from the wording choices in an inconsequential email to the shade of blue used in the internal team website, you've taken it to the extreme. It can be a slippery slope from kindly wanting to be looped in to full-on micromanagement.

When we think of the controlling boss, we often think of someone yelling at their employees, telling them they don't cut it, and creating an all-around hostile work environment. But this is often not the case. Micromanaging is being overly prescriptive on tasks and follow-ups—to the point of taking learning opportunities away from your team and decreasing overall team performance. Yes, your greatest weakness *can* be that you care too much.

This can be especially hard for new managers, who are working to make their mark as leaders while feeling pressure to perform well and prove themselves to their direct reports and boss. But fear not, there are ways to break the cycle.

Talk About the Outcome, Not the Process

When you ask someone to complete a task, look closely at how you frame it. For instance, if you say, "I'd like a workshop organized with [people], on [day], covering [topics], to get to [resolution]," you've figuratively and literally spelled out the whole process for someone. This level of detail and direction makes people feel like you don't trust them to figure things out, or that they're just here to follow marching orders.

Sometimes, marching orders are exactly what a task requires. But whenever possible, you should give people the autonomy and space they need to step up and be leaders. This is what great managers do—they allow people to experiment, make mistakes, learn, and grow, so that they can become stronger performers.

The next time you assign someone a task or project, talk about the outcome you want—not every step you want them to take along the way. In her book *Dare to Lead*, Brené Brown discusses the concept of "painting success." This means talking with your team about what done looks like and what a good job looks like to keep everyone on the same page.

In the example, the outcome you're looking for is the resolution. Start there. Do a detailed problem analysis, and then say to your team members, "I'm looking to achieve this outcome. How would you approach it?" Let them share. Even if you don't agree with their proposal, you've showed them that you trust them, that you're interested in their ideas, and that you value their contributions.

Set Expectations Around Feedback

If you've read to the end of the previous section, you may be thinking, "But what if my team's plan won't get me the outcome I'm looking for?"

To protect yourself from this problem, discuss when and how you'll be giving your team members constructive feedback at the start of each new project. Basically, set boundaries, but also give people space to breathe, experiment, and make mistakes within those bounds. Creativity, after all, thrives under constraints.

When you're setting expectations for how you'll give feedback, you should discuss the type of feedback you'll be sharing. Will you want to line-edit their proposal or just give directional feedback on the content? In these moments, try to stay objective and check yourself for any micromanaging tendencies.

For example, if you're eager to line-edit, ask yourself why. Who is the audience you're trying to impress? If the proposal is for an internal team meeting, do you really need to fix every slightly long sentence? Probably not. If the proposal is going out to the press or senior stakeholders, fine, open the floodgates.

Your feedback should match the consequences, and when the stakes are low and the feedback is overly detailed, it can make someone feel like they're being picked on. And when someone feels picked on, they're not in a headspace to learn.

Manage Up When Possible

Now you might be thinking, "But the work of my direct reports reflects on *me*. If it isn't perfect, it looks like I did a bad job." Not necessarily, and certainly not if you've done a good job of managing up. Your role as a people manager is to develop your people, to help them build a thriving career, and to train them to be your predecessor one day. In doing this, you have to give people the space to grow and make their own unique mark on a team.

In conversations with your own manager, talk about your team members—areas where you're helping them stretch and grow, places where they're stepping up and shining, and what your plan is for the team long term. This gives you an opportunity to show your manager "I've got this" when something isn't quite perfect.

If you feel squeezed by your manager, it's likely you'll direct some of that back to your team, even if you *really* try not to. By talking to your manager about the very same things you talk to your team members about—what success looks like on a project and when and how you'll share feedback—you have an opportunity to check (1) if they agree on your definition of success, and (2) the ways and moments they can share feedback if they'd like to chime in as well.

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Managing teams is hard. It's even harder when we care. And it's even *even* harder when our team members don't do things in the exact same ways we do. But this diversity of thought is what results in growth, creativity, and innovation.

The last thing you want to do is wear someone down into working exactly like you and your own management chain. Celebrate the different ways of solving problems, of reaching successful outcomes, and create opportunities for people across your team to learn from each other. The more people feel like their ideas and ways of working are recognized and valued, the better work they do, and the longer they'll want to stay on your team.

If you're stuck in a cycle of micromanaging, it's not too late. Start right now. Let go a little bit and watch your team members rise to the occasion.

QUICK RECAP

Micromanaging can take away learning opportunities from your team and decrease overall performance. Here's how to avoid it:

- The next time you assign someone a task or project, talk about the outcome you want, not every step you want them to take along the way.
- Discuss when and how you'll be giving your team members feedback at the start of each new project, and ensure that your level of feedback matches the consequences.
- Manage up to avoid feeling squeezed by your own manager. It's likely you'll direct their micromanagement back to your team, even if you try not to.

Adapted from content posted on hbr.org, September 9, 2022.

Worried you might be a micromanager? Read this article:



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A Better Way to Develop and Retain Top Talent

by Margaret Rogers

Workers with capabilities that allow them to keep up with the rapid pace of change in today's work environments—such as adaptability, technological literacy, and people management—are in steep demand. But employers are struggling to keep them on board.

One of your duties as a manager is to help develop and retain the top talent on your team. And in my experience, the most impactful development happens in small moments that occur within the workplace every day: on-the-job learning opportunities that are wholeheartedly catered to the worker's unique needs and challenges.

It might seem impossible to offer every employee this kind of personalized training, but any company can do so at scale when managers create a learning environment. Here's how.

Ask More Questions to Gain Insights on Employees

Just as a business must understand what its customers need to produce the most useful products, managers must understand what their employees need to give them ideal learning opportunities. Asking questions is the best way to do this.

Start by scheduling regular one-on-one meetings with each team member. In addition to using this time to check in on their current projects, ask them what skills they're most comfortable with and which they would like to develop. Inquire about areas that feel especially challenging.

Here are a few examples you can use to kick-start that process:

- What parts of your job are most interesting and rewarding?
- What areas are you finding most challenging right now?
- What are you doing to reach short- and long-term career goals?
- Are there any other projects, committees, or additional responsibilities you would like to be a part of?
- Is there anything else you're curious about that you haven't been able to explore yet?

In these meetings, practice active listening and try to come from a place of genuine curiosity rather than judgment. This means leaving your laptop closed and taking notes the old-fashioned way. It's also helpful to repeat what employees say during meetings in your own words to ensure you are fully understanding their insights.

Create More On-the-Job Opportunities

Once you've identified the skills your team members want to learn, look for opportunities to help people develop them. Classroom-style training is a stellar foundation, but it can lose its effectiveness if it isn't applied readily. "Learning moments" are an easier, quicker way to move the needle. These moments can be significant or small, but engaging employees in this way is key to helping them step outside their comfort zones, practice, and build confidence.

For example, imagine one of your employees is uncomfortable having tough yet necessary conversations. In a one-on-one meeting, he might express frustration about a peer whom he is struggling to collaborate with. You could take this opportunity to create a learning moment. This might be role-playing a tricky conversation or writing down a step-by-step plan of action. In this way, you are helping your team member practice and improve his communication skills in a safe setting (as opposed to simply sharing theoretical advice). The next time he comes across a similar situation, he will have tools to help him overcome it.

Treating every challenge your employees face as an opportunity for practice and growth—whether it is something personal, like improving communication skills, or practical, like learning a new technology—is critical to establishing an environment in which people believe they are valued enough as individuals to be given the time and space to flourish. It also gives managers the chance to help their employees effectively upskill and reskill on a case-by-case basis as new obstacles arise outside of formal trainings and in everyday work experiences.

Vary Learning Experiences

Consider which experiences will best cater to your direct reports' needs. Factors such as the employee's tenure, experience level, and adaptability are all variables that could impact your approach. Smaller opportunities—say, participation in projects where the employee can rely on more experienced peers for support—are best when a team member is unfamiliar with or new to a necessary skill. Bigger opportunities that require employees to take risks and stretch beyond their comfort zones are more suited to individuals who have prior experience carrying out a certain task; in these moments, they can put their skills to the test more independently and play a larger role.

Pretend, for example, you have two employees who express interest in public speaking and presentations. They both recognize it's a valuable skill to develop as they work toward becoming leaders. From previous meetings, you know one of them is less experienced than the other and is therefore more nervous about speaking in public. This employee might benefit more from a small group setting, like a lunch-and-learn during which he gives a short presentation. Because the other employee has had more practice in this area, a lunch-and-learn would not be as valuable for her. Instead, you might have her fly solo and present on a topic at the next companywide meeting or at a conference in front of a larger audience.

Save the most significant opportunities for those who are ready. These have higher stakes—for the employee, the project, and the company at large.

The level of control employees have over their growth should also vary. You might encourage a more experienced employee to design or seek out their own opportunities for growth, but a less experienced employee often requires more structure in key learning areas. Either way, it's crucial to allow employees a level of autonomy. When left alone, people will naturally find innovative ways to accomplish new things. Experimenting with autonomy also allows mistakes to be made—just as much as it allows successes to be had. This will help you identify skill gaps and brainstorm ways people can fill them.

Remember, safety is necessary when confidence is low, but pushing employees to the edge of discomfort results in real development.

Provide Regular Feedback

Feedback is perhaps the most valuable aspect of this process, and it starts with setting clear expectations. As your team continues to carry out on-the-job opportunities, work with employees to set goals to strive toward. Provide regular feedback on what they are doing well and where you see opportunities for improvement.

During this time, be patient. Reflect on the work your employee has done up to this point, making sure to discuss both successes and failures without judgment. If an employee tried something new and it didn't pan out, recognize the effort. People are more likely to grow from their experiences when they aren't punished for failure. (In fact, they're probably kicking themselves already.)

In the same vein, you can ensure employees actively apply what they've learned by putting together a plan for improvement—whether that means creating clearer deadlines, helping them better manage their time, or thinking through difficult problems when they arise. Tracking personal metrics is also a helpful way for employees to measure performance and growth on their own time.

Manage Your Time

Employee development can be overwhelming, especially when you have a large number of direct reports. Take proactive steps to avoid ending up with an unmanageable workload. Before shaping opportunities, determine how much bandwidth you have. What level of involvement and support are you capable of giving as a manager, considering everything else on your plate? Setting realistic expectations for yourself is critical.

Not all coaching has to come from you. In some cases, you may be able to distribute employee-support tasks to informal mentors, other managers, senior leaders, or peers.

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When leaders try to implement these user-centered principles in their interactions, experiment with them, and continually refine their coaching based on those findings, they not only will see astounding growth but will be able to effectively engage and retain top talent. Any company can begin by making a few changes to its managerial practices. It's time for leaders to open communication channels and address each employee personally. Help your workers shape their learning and long-term contributions for the better.

QUICK RECAP

To develop and retain the top talent on your team, create an everyday learning environment.

- Ask your employees what skills they're most comfortable with and which they would like to develop.
 - Treat every challenge your employees face as an opportunity for practice and growth.
 - Consider which experiences will best cater to your direct reports' needs.
 - Save the most significant opportunities for those who are ready, since these have higher stakes.
 - Provide employees with regular feedback on what they are doing well and where you see areas for improvement.
 - Set realistic expectations for what level of involvement and support you are capable of giving as a manager.
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